Akbar’s terrible anger towards Salim remains something of a mystery, one that clearly confounded someone as close to him as Abu’l Fazl. Perhaps the Padshah had already been in a volatile mood due to Tansen’s death, when he had planned the journey to Kashmir so precipitously. He would have been feeling the strain of several weeks’ arduous journey, too, but his anger at Salim nonetheless seems to indicate an undercurrent of strain simmering between the Padshah and his sons. Akbar’s reluctance to send the princes away from the court meant that there were now three additional, constantly growing princely households in claustrophobic intimacy, exacerbating potential tensions. Just as the princes increasingly baulked at the strictures on their actions, Akbar, too, appeared unwilling to accept challenges to his authority and orders. The clash between Akbar, now approaching fifty, and the refined and elegant Salim was entirely unequal. Too young and inexperienced to be able to openly withstand the fury of his father’s will at this stage, Salim would begin to develop sly ways of mounting his own challenge to his father, often through secret alliances and opportunistic friendships.

The Mughal party now continued on to Srinagar, reaching the capital of Kashmir on 5 June where crowds of people thronged the Padshah. The Mughals were delighted with the city where, Abu’l Fazl noted, the houses were made of wood, up to five storeys high, with tulips planted on the rooftops. Cattle were kept on the lower floor, the family apartments were on the second floor while the topmost floors contained the various household stores. They were enchanted, too, by the dense shade of the chinar trees, the saffron flowers, and the waterfalls. Abu’l Fazl was less enchanted with the musicians. He wrote that musicians were ‘exceeding many and equally monotonous, and with each note they seem to dig their nails into your liver’. Through the reigns of Jahangir, and then his son Shah Jahan, Kashmir would become, for the Mughals, a place of pastoral delight and earthly perfection.

> The country is enchanting, and might be fittingly called a garden of perpetual spring surrounding a citadel terraced to the skies, and deservedly appropriate to be either the delight of the worldling or the abode of the dervish. Its streams are sweet to the taste, its waterfalls music to the ear, and its climate is invigorating. The enchanting flowers fill the heart with delight. Violets, the red rose